

THE TECH PUSH
Applicants undergoing biometrics at a Passport Seva Kendra in Defence Colony, Delhi

HARDIK CHHABRA

A QUICK PASSAGE

The digitised sytem for applications at Passport Seva Kendras has made the process of issuing everyone's essential travel document quick and efficient

By PRADIP R. SAGAR

PASSPORT SEVA PROGRAMME
Launched in 2010

Achievement: Over 100 million passports issued so far, with processing time down to 7-10 days

THE DRUDGERY

As an expanding middle class, driven by India's post-liberalisation boom of the 1990s, found itself wanting to travel abroad, be it for tourism, business or education, it encountered a frequent barrier to that ambition—getting a passport in time. The Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) struggled with inadequate infrastructure and outdated systems, with processing times stretching into weeks and even months. A major bottleneck was the police verification process, notorious for inefficiency and corruption. Bribery demands were rampant and refusal often led to deliberate delays or unwarranted hurdles. The limited number of passport offices and serpentine queues forced desperate applicants to turn to touts who made easy money by exploiting the system's inefficiencies. Despite efforts toward automation and decentralisation, the manual processes persisted, resulting in errors and delays and screaming for a solution.